Consumer Behaviour Insights [MKT01]

FIIB

Enter to Learn, Leave to Succeed

Exploring Fashion Inclusivity: A Thematic Analysis of r/TransFashionAdvice Discussions

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Introduction

Fashion plays a significant role in identity formation and self-expression, particularly for transgender and non-binary individuals navigating social visibility and body changes. This study analyzes discussions from the Reddit community *r/TransFashionAdvice* to explore how fashion and identity intersect in real-world experiences. Approximately 29 posts and comment threads were manually reviewed and coded in a Google Sheet to identify recurring challenges, emotional responses, and brand-related concerns. The purpose of this analysis is to identify 3-5 major themes emerging from these discussions and to propose practical recommendations for fashion brands seeking to become more gender-inclusive and responsive to diverse body needs.

Now for the Themes that I discover: -

Theme 1: Functional Design Gaps in Women's Clothing

A dominant theme across the dataset was frustration with basic garment functionality. Many users reported shallow or fake pockets in women's clothing, describing them as impractical and symbolic of functional inequality. Other issues included sleeves that were too short, tight shoulder fits, inadequate anatomical space in feminine-cut pants, and poor upper-body support in bralettes and crop tops. These concerns reflect structural design limitations rather than aesthetic preferences. Users frequently expressed disappointment and avoidance behavior, indicating that lack of functional inclusivity discourages engagement with certain clothing categories. This suggests that mainstream design standards often fail to accommodate diverse body proportions.

Theme 2: Sizing Inconsistency and Body Changes During Transition

Another major theme was difficulty with inconsistent sizing across brands, especially for individuals experiencing body changes due to hormone replacement therapy (HRT). Users described needing to size up significantly for comfort despite technically fitting smaller sizes. Many expressed frustrations with unpredictable size charts and brand variation, particularly around shoulder width and rib cage fit. Body changes during transition also created financial stress, as clothing purchased early in transition often became unusable. This theme highlights both emotional and economic consequences of rigid and inconsistent sizing systems.

Theme 3: Emotional Impact and Dysphoria

Fashion choices were closely tied to emotional well-being. Several users described anxiety about shopping in gendered retail spaces and fear of judgment when browsing women's sections. Others discussed dysphoria related to body proportions and garment fit. Emotional reassurance, confidence-building strategies, and validation from supportive communities played an important role in navigating these experiences. Clothing was not just functional it served as a tool for identity affirmation and self-confidence. The emotional dimension of fashion consumption emerged as equally important as physical fit.

Theme 4: Inclusivity Gaps in the Fashion Market

Participants frequently noted limited availability of gender-neutral sections, feminine shoes in larger sizes, and inclusive plus-size options. Large-size offerings were often stereotyped or overly niche. This reflects a broader industry bias toward binary sizing and conventional body norms. The lack of accessible, diverse options suggests that current retail structures do not fully address the needs of gender-diverse consumers.

Theme 5: Consumer Adaptation and Workarounds

Due to market gaps, many users described adaptive strategies such as thrifting, tailoring, purchasing custom corsets, and using resale platforms like eBay. These strategies demonstrate creativity and resilience but also indicate unmet demand in mainstream fashion. Consumers are investing additional time and effort to modify garments that should ideally be inclusive by design.

Brand Recommendations

Based on the identified themes, several actionable recommendations emerge for fashion brands seeking to improve gender inclusivity.

First, brands should prioritize functional garment design. This includes deep and usable pockets, adjustable bra structures, extended sleeve and torso lengths, and anatomically considerate cuts. Functional equality should be treated as a core design standard rather than a premium feature.

Second, sizing systems must become more transparent and adaptable. Brands can introduce detailed measurement guides, shoulder and rib cage fit indicators, and adaptive or modular sizing elements. Standardizing measurements across collections would reduce confusion and improve trust.

Third, retail environments should become more inclusive. Creating gender-neutral sections, training staff in sensitivity and inclusive communication, and featuring diverse body representations in marketing campaigns can reduce shopping anxiety and enhance customer confidence.

Finally, brands could explore transitional wardrobe collections designed for individuals experiencing body changes. Adjustable, flexible garments that accommodate size fluctuation would address both emotional and financial concerns identified in the analysis.

AI Usage Disclosure

AI tools were used to assist with organizing and clustering coded keywords into broader thematic categories. ChatGPT was utilized for support in grouping similar issues and structuring the report outline. All themes, interpretations, and final conclusions were personally reviewed, edited, and understood before inclusion. The dataset was manually collected and coded by the researcher, and AI-generated suggestions were refined to reflect independent analysis. AI was used as a support tool for organization and drafting assistance, not as a substitute for critical thinking or original interpretation.

Excel Sheet link - https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/15-wqDngb-iYylHgGQSAkKNc6GdJ4K84z/edit?usp=sharing&ouid=109539322438595541485&rtpof=true&sd=true

Screenshots Folder Link - https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1hA3EUuwAhsOHn2MIWLx1dE-6PiZyyN7x?usp=sharing